

Hedgehogs and relatives

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Erinaceomorpha
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	24

Formerly classified with shrews and moles in the order Insectivora, hedgehogs and moonrats are larger—mostly nocturnal—animals, with proportionately bigger eyes and ears. Their coat has long hair (moonrats), or hairs on the back and sides are modified into protective spines (hedgehogs). When threatened, hedgehogs may roll into a spiny ball, concealing the vulnerable face and underparts. Moonrats are restricted to tropical Southeast Asia, but hedgehogs occur throughout Eurasia and Africa, and some species are adapted to deserts. Both groups are predators of small animals (mostly invertebrates), but hedgehogs take carrion, fruit, roots, and nuts, too.

IMMUNE SYSTEM
Immunity to snake venom allows a hedgehog to take advantage of any snake it comes across as a potential food source.



Erinaceus europaeus

European hedgehog



Length	9–10½ in (22–27 cm)
Tail	None
Weight	2–2¼ lb (0.9–1 kg)
Social unit	Individual
Status	Least concern

Location Europe



The densely spined European hedgehog roams in urban parks and gardens as well as in hedgerows, fields, and woods at night, nosing—with piglike snuffling (hence “-hog”)—for small animals such as worms, insects, and spiders. It also takes birds’ eggs and carrion. Its day shelter is a nest of grass and leaves under a bush, log, or outbuilding or in an old burrow. During hibernation, it may wake on mild nights to feed. Mating takes place from May to October and gestation takes 31–35 days. The spines of the 4–5 young appear within hours of birth.

SELF-ANOINTING



The purpose of “self-anointing,” when a hedgehog twists around to lick and smear its spines and skin with its own frothy saliva, is dependent on age, sex, and season. The saliva is mixed with a range of strong-smelling substances and toxins, and could be a way for hedgehogs to mask their own scent.

AGILE DEFENSE
The hedgehog runs and climbs with surprising agility. In self-defense it tucks its nonspiny head and legs onto its belly and rolls into a prickly ball.



Echinosorex gymnura

Moonrat



Length	10–18 in (26–46 cm)
Tail	6½–12 in (16–30 cm)
Weight	1–4½ lb (0.5–2 kg)
Social unit	Individual
Status	Least concern

Location S.E. Asia



Like other moonrats (gymnures), this species makes a territory-marking scent likened to rotting onions. It resembles a combination of hedgehog and small pig with harsh, rough, spiky outer fur, streaked with black and gray-white, and a long, scaly, almost hairless tail. Solitary, the moonrat rests in a burrow or crevice by day; at night it forages for small creatures such as insects, and also swims after fish and other aquatic prey.



Podogymnura truei

Mindanao moonrat



Length	5–6 in (13–15 cm)
Tail	1½–2¼ in (4–7 cm)
Weight	5–6 oz (150–175 g)
Social unit	Individual
Status	Least concern

Location S.E. Asia (Mindanao)



Inhabiting only one island in the Philippines, this poorly known but locally common species probably forages on the forest floor by day or night, especially around marshes and streams, for varied small animal prey. It lives alone, sheltering in a simple nest of leaves under a rock or log, or in an abandoned burrow. The long, soft fur is mainly gray-red, shading to gray-white on the underside. The distinctively pointed lower snout extends beyond the bottom lip, and the tail is short and coarse furred.

Paraechinus micropus

Indian hedgehog



Length	5½–9 in (14–23 cm)
Tail	¾–1½ in (1–4 cm)
Weight	11–16 oz (300–450 g)
Social unit	Individual
Status	Least concern

Location S. Asia



Similar to the long-eared hedgehog (see right) in appearance and habits, although slightly spinier, this species has a bare area of skin on the head. It is adapted to desert, dry scrub, and arid grassland, remaining inactive at times of harsh conditions (usually drought). Natural shelters such as rock crevices serve for nests, but the Indian hedgehog may dig a short burrow for this purpose. It hunts at night, seeking out insects, scorpions, and other small creatures. It also eats birds’ eggs and scavenges for carrion. This hedgehog may cache (store) food, carrying it back to the nest for later consumption. Coloration is extremely variable with very dark (melanic) and almost white (albino) hues relatively common in the wild, and also brown and yellow banding patterns. Young are born between April and September. There is usually only 1–2 per litter.

Hemiechinus auritus

Long-eared hedgehog



Length	6–10½ in (15–27 cm)
Tail	¾–2 in (1–5 cm)
Weight	⅞–⅝ oz (250–275 g)
Social unit	Individual
Status	Least concern

Location W., C., and E. Asia, N. Africa



Similar in appearance to the larger European hedgehog, the long-eared hedgehog has coarse fur on the face, limbs, and belly, but spines elsewhere. Banding on the spines varies from black through brown to yellow and white. It uses natural daytime resting places under rocks and shrubs. It eats various small animals and can become inactive when food or water are scarce.

